



RABBIT · *ORYCTOLAGUS CUNICULUS*

Keep your rabbit the right way from day one.

A complete, fact-checked printable manual: real space instead of a hutch, the hay-first diet that prevents most of what goes wrong, gastrointestinal (GI) stasis caught early, the law in every state, and the routines that keep a rabbit thriving for its full lifespan.

INSIDE

- ✓ Every measurement in feet and meters, every portion by body weight
- ✓ Two pages on GI stasis, the emergency every rabbit owner should recognize
- ✓ The peer-reviewed case for a bonded companion, and how to bond one
- ✓ A printable emergency card, pet-sitter sheet, and a droppings reference

49 pages

Beginner to Intermediate

Print or tablet

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CONTENTS

What's inside

Every page is written to be used, not just read once.

GETTING STARTED

How to Use This Package	3
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SECTION 01 · PROFILE

Quick Profile & Cost Overview	4
The Species, Breeds, Size & Lifespan	5

SECTION 02 · HOUSING & ENVIRONMENT

Enclosure Size, Type & Where It Goes	6
Flooring, the Litter Box & Litter	7
Temperature, Heat & Cold	8
Indoors Versus Outdoors	9
Rabbit-Proofing the Room	10
Cleaning & Hygiene	11

SECTION 03 · FEEDING

Diet by Age	12
Hay: the Base of the Diet	13
Greens, Vegetables & Pellets	14
Treats, the Never-Feed List & Water	15
Growth, Weight & Body Condition	16

SECTION 04 · HANDLING & BEHAVIOR

Handling & Building Trust	17
Body Language & Normal Behavior	18
Enrichment & Common Mistakes	19
Companionship & Bonding	20

SECTION 05 · ARRIVAL & LIFE STAGES

Choosing a Rabbit, Quarantine & the First Vet Visit	21
Sexing, Spay & Neuter	22
Molting, Grooming & Nails	23

SECTION 06 · THE LAW

Is a Rabbit Legal Where You Live?	24
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SECTION 07 · HEALTH & COMMON ISSUES

Red Flags & Finding a Vet	25
GI Stasis: What It Is & Why Rabbits Get It	26
GI Stasis: Signs, What to Do & Prevention	27
Dental Disease	28
Flystrike & Snuffles	29
Sore Hocks, Bladder Stones, Uterine Cancer & a Parasite	30
Rabbit Hemorrhagic Disease Vaccine & Antibiotics	31
Reading Droppings & Cecotropes	32

SECTION 08 · QUICK REFERENCE

Setup Checklist & Targets	33
Emergency & Quick Targets Card	34

SECTION 09 · OWNER TOOLS

Budget & Shopping List	35
First 30 Days	36
Symptom Quick Reference	37
Daily, Weekly & Seasonal Routine	38
Power Outages & Heat Waves	39
Leaving Town, Transport & Moving	40
Pet-Sitter Sheet	41
Owner Log	42
Care, Vet & Bonding Log	43
Enrichment Checklist & Log	44

REFERENCE

Glossary, A to G	45
Glossary, H to Z	46
Sources	47
Where the Sources Disagree	48
Version History & About	49

START HERE

How to use this package

Three ways to get value from it, depending on where you are right now.

UNITS USED THROUGHOUT

Every temperature and size is given twice: degrees Fahrenheit (°F) with degrees Celsius (°C), inches (in) and feet (ft) with centimeters (cm) or meters (m), square feet (sq ft) with square meters (m²), and pounds (lb) with kilograms (kg). The weight log is kept in grams (g), the unit a kitchen scale shows. Food is measured in cups and tablespoons (tbsp), water in milliliters (mL), and prices are in United States dollars.

If you haven't set up yet

Read pages 4 through 11 in order before buying anything, and the arrival and spay pages (21 and 22) before you bring a rabbit home. Two decisions cost the most to reverse: how much space the rabbit gets, and whether it is spayed or neutered. Get both right first, then use the Budget & Shopping List on page 35.

If your rabbit is already home

Audit what you have against the Setup Checklist on page 33. If hay is not unlimited and the bulk of the diet, fix that this week: it is the most protective habit available to you. If your rabbit is off its food right now, do not read further. Go to page 27, then call a vet today.

Print these first

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| ☐ Page 33: Setup Checklist & Targets | ☐ Page 41: Pet-Sitter Sheet |
| ☐ Page 34: Emergency & Quick Targets Card | ☐ Page 42: Owner Log |
| ☐ Page 37: Symptom Quick Reference | ☐ Page 43: Care, Vet & Bonding Log |
| ☐ Page 38: Daily, Weekly & Seasonal Routine | ☐ Page 44: Enrichment Checklist & Log |

WHY THIS PACKAGE EXISTS

Rabbits are sold as a starter pet and kept like a hamster, and almost everything that goes wrong follows from that one mistake. They are not a cage animal, and they are not a cheap animal once the vet is counted. This package reflects current welfare standards and peer-reviewed research, cross-checked against the sources on page 47.

NOT A SUBSTITUTE FOR

A rabbit-savvy exotic vet. This matters more for rabbits than for most pets: rabbit physiology, anesthetic protocols and drug tolerances differ enough from a dog's or cat's that a general small-animal clinic can miss or mishandle the conditions in Section 07. Find one before you need one, ideally through a local rabbit rescue.

SECTION 01 • PROFILE

Quick profile

Everything at a glance before you read the detail.

Scientific name	<i>Oryctolagus cuniculus</i> , the European rabbit, ancestor of more than 300 breeds
Adult size	Highly variable by breed: about 2.5 lb (1.1 kg) for the smallest to more than 20 lb (9 kg) for giants
Lifespan	8 to 12 years indoors, and some reach 14 or even 16. Outdoor rabbits average 3 to 5 years
Native range	The Iberian Peninsula (Spain and Portugal), spread across Europe by the Romans and now found worldwide
Diet type	Hindgut-fermenting herbivore: it digests fiber in the cecum, a fermentation chamber after the small intestine. Grass hay is 80 to 85% of the diet, unlimited (page 13)
Space minimum	8 sq ft (0.75 m ²) enclosure plus 24 sq ft (2.2 m ²) exercise space, 5 or more hours a day
The one hard rule	No food or droppings for 8 to 12 hours is a same-day vet call, not a wait-and-see (page 27)
Housing	Indoors. A neutered, bonded pair beats a single rabbit (page 20)
Handling difficulty	Beginner to intermediate. The spine is fragile, so support is not optional (page 17)
Conservation status	Endangered in the wild on the International Union for Conservation of Nature (IUCN) list of threatened species, though it is invasive where it has been introduced

Cost overview

Initial setup

\$125 to \$197 for the equipment, plus \$150 to \$500 or more for a spay or neuter, and \$25 to \$100 for an adoption fee that often includes the surgery. Every line is on page 35.

Every year after

\$924 to \$1,895: food and litter at \$62 to \$135 a month, two wellness exams, and the yearly vaccine booster. The first year runs \$1,219 to \$2,697, without the adoption fee.

THE NUMBER THAT CATCHES PEOPLE OUT

A GI stasis workup alone can exceed \$1,500, and rabbits need an exotic vet whose rates are higher than a general clinic's. Keep \$500 to \$1,000 set aside separately from the routine budget. Rabbits hide illness well, and when something goes wrong it goes wrong quickly.

Fun facts worth knowing

- They eat some of their droppings on purpose. Cecotropes are soft pellets eaten straight from the source, carrying B vitamins the gut bacteria made on the first pass. A rabbit that stops eating them is telling you something (page 32).
- Their teeth never stop growing, about 1 cm (0.4 in) a month, as much as 4 to 5 in (10 to 13 cm) a year. Hay is not a bedding material with a nutritional bonus, it is the dental equipment.
- Rabbit milk is so rich that a mother nurses once, rarely twice, a day for 2 to 10 minutes. Kits (baby rabbits) go roughly a day between feeds, so a nest left alone is usually normal, not abandoned.

The species, breeds, size & lifespan

What you are buying, how big it gets, and how long it stays.

One species, more than 300 breeds

Every pet rabbit, from a dwarf to a giant, is the same species: *Oryctolagus cuniculus*, the European rabbit. In the wild it lives in large underground warrens with strict social hierarchies, on grassland, meadow, farmland and forest edge, eating grasses, herbs, root vegetables and bark. It is a social animal that digs, which is why a single rabbit in a hutch is a compromise and why the digging in your living room is not misbehavior.

THE MONK AND THE LENT MYTH

The old story says rabbits were domesticated at a stroke around the year 600, when a pope ruled that newborn rabbits counted as fish and could be eaten in Lent. A graduate student sent to find the decree found that none exists. The story traces to a passage written in the year 584 about a man who ate young rabbits during Lent. Irving-Pease and Larson published the correction in 2018: domestication was a long process with no single starting point.

Size, breed and what changes in the care

SIZE	ADULT WEIGHT	SEXUALLY MATURE	NOTES
Small breeds, such as the Polish Dwarf and Dutch	from about 2.5 lb (1.1 kg)	3.5 to 4 months	More delicate, and needs especially careful handling
Medium breeds	about 7 to 12 lb (3.2 to 5.4 kg)	4 to 4.5 months	The size the standard space figures are written for
Giant breeds, such as the Flemish Giant	15 to 20 lb (6.8 to 9 kg), 2.5 to 4 ft (0.8 to 1.2 m) long	6 to 9 months	About 30 sq ft (2.8 m²) of base enclosure, more food, and a close eye on weight (pages 6, 14)

COAT OR FACE	WHAT IT CHANGES
Long-haired, angora	Brushing daily all year, and a higher flystrike risk (pages 23, 29)
Rex, and giants	More prone to sore hocks: Rex have less fur protecting the feet, and giants carry more weight on them. Soft, dry flooring and weight checks matter most
Lops, dwarf and mini breeds with short, flat faces	More likely to have dental problems, so the weekly mouth check matters most (page 28)

Larger rabbits are often calmer and sturdier. Temperament matters more than size or breed, in the pet and in a companion for it.

Lifespan

A rabbit kept indoors typically lives 8 to 12 years, and some reach 14 or even 16. Outdoor rabbits average 3 to 5, because of predators, weather and problems that go unnoticed without close daily contact. A wild rabbit lives 1 to 2 years. Plan for the whole span: a rabbit bought on impulse can outlast a lease, a school year and a dorm room.

Enclosure size, type & where it goes

A pen is the bedroom. The exercise space is the house.

The standard is at least 8 sq ft (0.75 m²) of enclosure combined with at least 24 sq ft (2.2 m²) of exercise space for one or two rabbits, with a minimum of 5 hours a day to run in it. In practice that means a large foldable metal exercise pen (an x-pen), 4×4 ft (1.2×1.2 m) or bigger, not a cage the rabbit is let out of occasionally. The wire hutch sold as a "rabbit cage" is a fraction of this, and current welfare standards consider it inadequate.

Permanent access beats scheduled access. A rabbit let out for an hour a day spends the other twenty-three confined, and the research on page 19 measured time-of-day effects for a reason: rabbits are crepuscular, most active at dawn and dusk, and want the room then, not when it suits the household.

What goes in the pen

ITEM	WHY
Litter box, with hay over it	Rabbits eliminate while they eat, so a hay rack over the box does most of the litter training.
A hide or cardboard castle	A prey animal needs somewhere to get underneath.
A platform to get on	An elevated spot let group-housed rabbits rest more comfortably and explore more.
A dig box	Soil, shredded paper or hay. Digging is normal burrowing behavior.
Water bowl and greens, and a second hay pile in a rack	Food and water within reach, and hay in more than one place.
Open floor, left clear	Room to run and to flop out flat. Do not fill every square foot.

Scaling up for large and giant breeds

The figures above describe an average rabbit. A rabbit's sleeping and resting area should be about four times its own size, and a cage used as a bedroom should run 3 to 4 times its stretched-out length. A 4×4 ft (1.2×1.2 m) pen suits most rabbits but not a giant. A Flemish Giant weighs 15 to 20 lb (6.8 to 9 kg) and stretches to 2.5 to 4 ft (0.8 to 1.2 m), so its base enclosure needs to be at least 36 in (91 cm) wide, 36 in (91 cm) tall and 120 in (3 m) long, about 30 sq ft (2.8 m²) on its own, and that size doubles for each additional rabbit. Floor time outside it matters just as much.

NEVER

House a rabbit in an aquarium or any solid-walled container. Ammonia from urine builds up in still air and irritates the airways over time, which is the slow road to snuffles (page 29). Wire floors are out for a different reason, covered on the next page.

Flooring, the litter box & litter

Soft under the feet, hay over the box, and the right litter in it.

Flooring

Skip wire flooring entirely. It contributes to sore hocks (page 30). Vinyl or linoleum over plywood, washable rugs, or fleece all give better traction and are easier on a rabbit's feet. A waterproof tarp under the whole setup protects your actual floor from the inevitable accidents.

Weight changes the question. A heavy rabbit puts more pressure on its hocks, so a solid, cushioned floor such as fleece over a yoga mat is the standard for giants. Carpet is abrasive and best avoided, and the floor has to be kept clean so urine and droppings do not cake onto the feet.

Litter training, which is easier than it sounds

Rabbits eliminate almost reflexively while they eat, so the trick is not teaching a new behavior, it is routing an existing one. Put the hay directly in or immediately over the litter box, and most of the training does itself.

USE A BIG BOX

A large, cat-litter-box-style container, not the small corner boxes marketed for rabbits. It needs room to sit and eat at once.

RIGHT LITTER

Paper-based or compressed wood-pellet litter, with the hay on top or in a rack directly above it.

SPAY OR NEUTER

If training stalls with an intact rabbit, this is often the reason. Spaying or neutering improves litter habits meaningfully (page 22).

NEVER USE THESE LITTERS

Clumping cat litter, which can cause serious problems if eaten, and pine or cedar shavings, whose aromatic oils irritate the airways. Both are sold in the small-pet aisle, and both are wrong here.

Temperature, heat & cold

No heat lamp and no dial to check: the room is the whole climate system.

Rabbits are far better at cold than at heat. They cannot sweat, and they shed heat mainly through the ears, where blood vessels dilate to carry warmth away. That is a much smaller radiator than a human's whole sweating skin, which is why a room that feels fine to you can already be too warm for a rabbit.

RANGE	WHAT IT MEANS
61 to 72°F (16 to 22°C)	The comfortable range. A normal indoor room needs no intervention.
About 80°F (26 to 27°C)	The line. Heat risk climbs from here, so keep the room at or below it. Move to the coolest room and do not wait to see how the rabbit copes.
Temperature plus humidity of 150	Add the room temperature in °F to the humidity percentage and keep the total at 150 or lower. Eighty-five degrees at 65% humidity adds up to 150, so a room that does not feel unbearable can already be a risk.
Cold	A rabbit tolerates subzero outdoor temperatures with proper shelter. Indoors, a draft or damp bedding causes far more cold-related illness than a steadily cool room.

Heat stress arrives in an order

1. **Fast, shallow or open-mouth breathing.** Sometimes visible as panting.
2. **Drooling or salivating**, which can leave the fur around the mouth wet. Red or very hot ears often come with it.
3. **Weakness and reluctance to move**, a rabbit lying stretched flat and hard to rouse.
4. **Severe signs:** tremors, convulsions, collapse or unconsciousness. This is an emergency, and the first sign, not the fourth, is the point to act.

Do

- Move the rabbit to the coolest room, ideally with air conditioning or good airflow away from direct sun.
- Offer cool, not ice-cold, water. Do not force it.
- Cool it gradually: a cool, damp towel or a light wipe of cool water on the ears and feet.
- Call a vet straight away. Heat stress can look like it is resolving and then relapse.

Don't

- Don't plunge a rabbit into cold or ice water. The shock can send an already-stressed animal into collapse.
- Don't assume it will recover on its own once it looks calmer.
- Don't leave a rabbit in a parked car, even briefly. A closed car crosses into heat stress well before it feels warm to you.

WHEN THE POWER FAILS IN SUMMER

A frozen water bottle wrapped in a towel gives the rabbit a cool surface to lie against, which is not the same as a cold-water plunge. The full blackout plan is on page 39.

Indoors versus outdoors

A lifespan decision, not a preference, and the gap is larger than almost any other choice in this book.

WHERE	TYPICAL LIFESPAN	WHY
Indoors	8 to 12 years, some to 14 or 16	You see the rabbit daily and closely, which is how illness is caught in the hours that matter.
Outdoors	About 3 to 5 years	Predators, extreme weather, and health problems that go unnoticed without daily close contact.

The second half is what people underestimate. A rabbit outdoors is exposed to predators and heat, and it is also out of sight. The window between a rabbit going off its food and being in genuine danger is measured in hours (page 27), and nobody notices it from indoors.

If a rabbit does live outside

RISK	WHAT TO DO
Predators	A backyard hutch does not protect a rabbit. Dogs, feral cats, raccoons and coyotes bend wire and open latches, and the mere presence of a predator can send a rabbit into a panic that ends in injury. Most predators hunt at night, so an outdoor rabbit comes inside each evening. By day, a sturdy covered pen is enough if people are close by.
Digging	Dirt in a yard pen holds harmful bacteria and invites tunnels the rabbit can vanish into when it needs help. Give the digging instinct a box of clean straw instead.
Heat	Shade and airflow first, because rabbits overheat. Wet towels hung over the side of the enclosure, or ice frozen in cardboard cartons set inside, cool a rabbit that has to sit out the heat.
Poisons	A rabbit cannot tell a poisonous plant by taste or smell, and lawn chemicals and fertilizers are poison too. Check every plant in the yard, and keep the rabbit in a pen indoors or in the yard until the poisonous ones are gone.
Inattention	A rabbit that is fed and watered but rarely handled or checked develops problems nobody notices until it is too late. Look at the rear end once or twice a day for flystrike (page 29).

BRING IT IN

Even a well-kept outdoor rabbit comes inside at night, in extreme weather, in a heat wave and whenever it is ill, and its owner expects to catch problems later than with an indoor rabbit.

Rabbit-proofing the room

Chewing is not naughtiness. It is a set of teeth that never stop growing doing their job.

Proof the space rather than fighting the instinct. A rabbit loose in the house will bite through anything that looks like a cord or a string, and the shock from a live electric cord is the most immediate danger it faces. That makes cords the single most important step in preparing a room, and it is why the pen is ready before the rabbit comes home: it protects the rabbit while you assess the rest.

The room checklist

- ☐ Every cord the rabbit can reach in split plastic tubing, or blocked off with furniture, outlets included
- ☐ Cords that run across the rabbit's path, or under the couch, handled first: they are the most tempting
- ☐ Every houseplant identified, and the poisonous ones moved out of reach
- ☐ An uncarpeted floor where possible, since carpet fiber swallowed in quantity can block the gut
- ☐ A chew and dig outlet next to each place the rabbit favors
- ☐ Hay, plain wood, cardboard or untreated straw mats within reach

Why each one matters

HAZARD	WHAT TO KNOW
Electric cords	Rabbits have an instinct to sever any cord or string. Watching a rabbit is not enough, because a bite through a cord takes a moment.
Houseplants	A rabbit cannot judge a plant by taste or smell, so it will eat a poisonous one that is within reach.
Carpet and synthetic fiber	Swallowed in quantity, it can block the digestive system, and a blockage is an emergency.
Young rabbits	A rabbit under a year old jumps up, over and into furniture and misjudges falls, so it needs watching until it settles. A mature rabbit is less adventurous and can have unsupervised freedom after a period of observation.

GIVE THE BEHAVIOR SOMEWHERE TO GO

Proofing alone moves the problem. Pair every block with an outlet: a dig box by the carpet corner a rabbit favors, and bamboo sticks, untreated willow or plain cardboard where it chews. A rabbit with nowhere to dig or chew picks somewhere, and not the somewhere you would choose. Neutering also lessens the urge to redecorate (page 22).

Cleaning & hygiene

Frequent cleaning is health care as well as housekeeping.

HOW OFTEN	WHAT
Every day	Clean the toilet area. Remove soiled litter and any wet bedding. Wash the water bowl rather than topping it up. Look at the rear end, fur and skin, twice a day in warm weather.
About once a week	Clean the whole enclosure. Do it more often if the rabbit soils the space, and more often again with each additional rabbit you keep together.

A cleaning day, step by step

- ☐ Empty the toilet area and wash it with a non-toxic cleaner
- ☐ Make sure everything is completely dry before the rabbit goes back in
- ☐ Put a little of the used bedding back, so the space smells familiar
- ☐ Restock hay in the rack and over the litter box
- ☐ Keep the toilet area apart from where the rabbit sleeps

WHY A CLEAN-OUT CAN UPSET A RABBIT

A clean-out disrupts a rabbit's routine, which is stressful for a prey animal. The used bedding left in is what keeps the space recognizable.

What dirty actually costs

PROBLEM	HOW IT FOLLOWS FROM A DIRTY SPACE
Respiratory disease	Ammonia from built-up urine and manure irritates the airways and sets a rabbit up for snuffles. Pneumonia cases rise with the ammonia level in the enclosure (page 29).
Flystrike	In a warm spot, the mess draws flies, and flies lay eggs on soiled fur. A rabbit with a permanently mucky bottom has a cause, such as diet, teeth, weight or arthritis, that needs finding, not only cleaning.
Sore hocks	The floor has to be kept clean so urine and droppings do not cake onto the feet (page 30).

SECTION 03 · FEEDING

Diet by age

The diet changes twice: once off alfalfa, and once into old age.

STAGE	FEEDING
Nursing kits birth to about 7 weeks	Mother's milk, and she nurses just once, rarely twice, a day for 2 to 10 minutes. Rabbit milk is unusually rich, so kits can go roughly a day between feeds. A nest left alone is normal, not abandoned. Weaned by around 8 weeks.
Transition 3 to 7 weeks	Alfalfa hay and alfalfa-based pellets introduced with free-choice access alongside nursing. New greens typically start around 12 weeks, in small amounts.
Juvenile 7 weeks to about 6 months	Unlimited alfalfa hay and alfalfa-based pellets: the extra calories and calcium support growth. Vegetables are added gradually from about 3 months, one new item at a time.
Changeover roughly 4 to 7 months	Alfalfa is phased out in favor of grass hays, and pellet portions are reduced gradually over several weeks as unlimited grass hay takes over as the base of the diet. Do this slowly.
Adult 7 months to about 6 years	Unlimited grass hay at 80 to 85% of the diet. Measured pellets, roughly 1/8 to 1/4 cup of high-fiber, timothy-based pellets per 5 to 6 lb (2.3 to 2.7 kg) of body weight daily. At least 3 varieties of leafy greens a day (page 14). Treats capped at about 1 to 2 tbsp, once or twice a week.
Senior about 6 years and up	Unlimited grass hay continues. Alfalfa may come back if the rabbit is underweight, the treat allowance is higher, and feeding becomes individual and vet-guided rather than by the table.

FRESH WATER AT EVERY STAGE

Water must be available at all times, by bowl or bottle. Which is better is on page 15.

CHANGE FOOD SLOWLY, ALWAYS

There is no gut-loading or calcium dusting here, that is a reptile practice. The rabbit equivalent of getting it wrong is changing food too fast. A sudden switch of hay, pellets or vegetables upsets the gut bacteria in the cecum, the fermentation chamber, and can bring soft stool or a stasis episode. Make every change over a week or two.

THE ONE FIGURE TO HOLD ON TO

Past 8 hours without food or droppings, a rabbit should be seen by a vet. At 12 hours or more it is an emergency, so 8 is when you make the call and 12 is when you are already late. Fasting beyond about 24 hours risks fatty liver disease. Same-day vet contact is the safe default the moment a rabbit skips a meal or stops producing normal droppings, at any age (page 27).

Hay: the base of the diet

If you take one thing from this package, take this page.

Grass hay should be 80 to 85% of what an adult rabbit eats, available 24 hours a day, never rationed. It does two jobs at once, and both are the jobs that kill rabbits when they are not done.

JOB ONE: THE GUT

Rabbits are hindgut fermenters, and the gut has to keep moving. Long-strand fiber is what moves it. Low fiber is the biggest risk factor for GI stasis (page 26).

JOB TWO: THE TEETH

Teeth grow about 1 cm (0.4 in) a month, and an incisor with nothing to wear against can grow 1 millimeter (mm) a day. Grinding long hay wears them down. Pellets are concentrated and do not do this.

The shape of the diet

PART OF THE DIET	SHARE	NOTES
Grass hay	80 to 85%	Unlimited, fresh daily
Leafy greens	about 10%	Rotated varieties
Pellets	about 5%	Measured, roughly 1/8 to 1/4 cup per 5 to 6 lb (2.3 to 2.7 kg) daily
Treats	0 to 5%	Carrots and fruit are high in sugar

Which hay

HAY	WHO	NOTES
Timothy, orchard grass	Adults	The common ones. Lower in protein and calcium than a legume hay, which is why they suit a mature rabbit.
Oat, brome	Adults	Also work. Mixing types keeps a picky rabbit eating.
Alfalfa	Under about 6 months	A legume, not a grass. Right for kits, juveniles, nursing does (adult females) and underweight seniors. Too rich for a healthy adult: the calcium and calories contribute to obesity and bladder sludge.

Making hay take time

Hay is also the cheapest enrichment here, and presentation matters. Stuff it into cardboard tubes, hang it in bundles, scatter greens through it, and keep a rack over the litter box so eating and toileting happen in the same corner, which is where the rabbit wants them anyway. One rabbit-sized bundle is a rough guide to what a rabbit eats in a day.

A RABBIT NOT EATING HAY IS A PROBLEM, NOT A PREFERENCE

The two usual reasons are that pellets or treats are filling it up, in which case cut those back, or that eating hurts, which means dental disease and a vet visit (page 28). Both need acting on. If anything in a rabbit's budget gets cut, it should never be the hay: every other part of the diet can be adjusted later, and teeth that have already overgrown cannot.

Greens, vegetables & pellets

Everything that is not hay, in order of how much of it there should be.

FOOD	HOW MUCH, FOR AN ADULT	NOTES
Grass hay	Unlimited, 80 to 85% of the diet	Never measured, never empty.
Fresh vegetables, mostly leafy greens	At least 2 cups per 6 lb (2.7 kg) a day, with at least 3 varieties of leafy greens	Introduce anything new one item at a time and watch for soft stool.
Pellets	1/8 to 1/4 cup per 5 to 6 lb (2.3 to 2.7 kg) daily	Plain, high-fiber, timothy-based. Measured, never free-fed.
Fruit and treats	About 1 to 2 tbsp, once or twice a week	Not daily, and not carrots as a staple.

By body weight

ADULT WEIGHT	PELLETS PER DAY	VEGETABLES PER DAY
3 lb (1.4 kg), dwarf	About 1/8 cup	At least 1 cup
6 lb (2.7 kg)	About 1/4 cup	At least 2 cups
12 lb (5.4 kg)	About 1/2 cup	At least 4 cups
18 lb (8.2 kg), giant	About 3/4 cup	At least 6 cups

Giants such as the Flemish are prone to obesity, so hold them at the lower end of the pellet range and let hay make up the difference. A rabbit-savvy vet can tune the figures for your rabbit.

Greens and vegetables by tier

FOOD	TIER	NOTES
Romaine, cilantro, parsley, basil, arugula, bok choy, carrot tops, mint	DAILY	The bulk of the fresh portion. Rotate at least three a day.
Bell pepper, cucumber, carrot	LIMITED	More sugar and starch than their reputation. Small pieces only.
Apple, banana, strawberry, blueberry	TREAT	Part of the 1 to 2 tbsp a week.

Pellets

A fresh, high-fiber, plain timothy-based pellet, not a colorful mix with seeds, nuts or dried fruit. Mixes are linked to obesity and dental disease, because the rabbit eats the sweet pieces and leaves the fiber. Pellets are measured for adults, never free-fed the way hay is.

KEEP THE WEIGHT HONEST

Rabbits pick the richest parts of a meal, which is why they gain weight easily on pellets and treats. Weigh weekly and feel the body monthly (page 16).

Treats, the never-feed list & water

Fruit is a treat: 1 to 2 tbsp in total, once or twice a week.

FOOD	VERDICT	NOTES
Parsley, cilantro, basil, mint	SAFE	Fresh herbs are safe in small amounts and count toward the daily greens.
Small pieces of apple, banana, strawberry, blueberry	TREAT	1 to 2 tbsp in total, once or twice a week.
Bell pepper, cucumber, carrot	LIMITED	Small amounts, and not carrots as a staple.
Iceberg lettuce	SKIP	Not toxic, but nearly empty nutritionally and upsetting in quantity.
Muesli-style mixes with seeds, nuts or colored pieces	NEVER	Rabbits eat the sweet bits and leave the fiber. Linked to obesity and dental disease.
Avocado	NEVER	Can cause respiratory distress and fatal heart failure.
Chocolate	NEVER	Toxic, as it is to most pets.
Onion, garlic, chives	NEVER	Can cause hemolytic anemia, the destruction of red blood cells.
Rhubarb	NEVER	High oxalic acid, linked to kidney damage.
Bread, crackers, cereal, yogurt drops	NEVER	Yogurt drops are sold as rabbit treats and are explicitly inappropriate.

Water

A rabbit drinks about 120 mL per kilogram of body weight a day, roughly twice what a dog or cat of the same size drinks. A 6 lb (2.7 kg) rabbit takes about 11 fluid ounces (325 mL). Rabbits drink significantly more from an open bowl than from a sipper bottle, so a heavy, flat-bottomed bowl is the better default, and a giant needs a big, heavy one that is checked and refilled more than once a day.

- A rabbit that gets a sore, damp chin from a bowl does better with a bottle. Rabbits chew the valve of a bottle, so a stainless steel one lasts longest.
- Whichever you use, change the water every day, and wash a bowl rather than topping it up.
- Dehydration slows the gut directly. Greens that carry moisture help, and in a blackout, keep water in more than one container.

THE NEVER-FEED LIST, IN ONE PLACE

Avocado · chocolate · onion, garlic and chives · rhubarb · muesli-style mixes · bread, crackers, cereal and yogurt drops. Iceberg lettuce is not toxic, but skip it too. Anyone feeding the rabbit should have this list.

Growth, weight & body condition

A change in weight is often the first sign of illness, and a slow drift is easy to miss by eye.

Maturity follows breed size

Rabbits reach sexual maturity at about 3.5 to 4 months in small breeds such as the Polish Dwarf and the Dutch, 4 to 4.5 months in medium breeds, and 6 to 9 months in giants, so the timing of a spay or neuter follows breed size more than the calendar. Adult weight runs from about 2.5 lb (1.1 kg) to more than 20 lb (9 kg), and healthy for your rabbit is its own figure, not a breed average.

Weigh weekly, feel monthly

Weigh once a week on a kitchen scale that reads in grams and write the number on the owner log (page 42). Once a month, feel the body as well, because a thick coat hides fat. Body condition is scored on a 9-point scale, and 4 to 5 is the usual ideal for an adult.

SCORE	WHAT THE HANDS FIND
1 to 3, thin	Ribs, spine and hips feel sharp under little or no padding. The back is flat or sunken, and the belly is tucked up.
4 to 5, ideal	Ribs and spine are easy to feel with gentle pressure under a light, even layer. The back is gently rounded, the rump feels firm and filled, and the belly has a slight tuck.
6 to 7, overweight	Ribs and spine take firm pressure to find. The back is broad and rounded, the dewlap (the fold of skin under the chin) is noticeably padded, and the belly has lost its tuck.
8 to 9, obese	Ribs and spine are very hard or impossible to feel. The rump bulges, the dewlap is large and folded, and the belly sags.

A HOME SCORE IS AN ESTIMATE

Anything outside 4 to 5, or any doubt, is a question for a rabbit-experienced vet before the diet changes. Weight alone cannot show whether a change is fat or muscle.

What to do with the numbers

- **Gaining:** cut pellets, treats and fruit first, and never the hay. Rabbits pick the richest parts of a meal, which is why they gain easily on pellets, fruit and treats.
- **Losing:** weight loss is a reason for a vet visit, not a diet tweak. Dental disease is the usual first suspect (page 28).
- **Any change, either way:** make it gradual. Never cut food to the point that a rabbit stops eating, which is the stasis emergency (page 26).

GIANTS

Giants such as the Flemish are prone to obesity, so hold them at the lower end of the pellet range and let hay make up the difference. Their flooring and weight checks matter more, because extra weight lands on the hocks.

Handling & building trust

Rabbits are more fragile than almost any first-time owner expects, and getting this wrong breaks bones.

WHY SUPPORT IS THE WHOLE THING

A rabbit that struggles against an unsupported hold can fracture its own lower back, the lumbar spine. Its hind legs are powerful enough to do that, and without full body support that power works in exactly the wrong direction. This is not a handling preference. It is the single most important physical thing to get right with this species.

Picking one up

1. One hand on the chest just behind the front legs, the other under the hindquarters. Both at once, never one then the other.
2. Lift with both regions supported, and bring the rabbit straight in against your body, not out at arm's length.
3. Stay low to the ground for the whole session, so a struggle ends in a short drop rather than a long one.
4. If it struggles, lower it back down immediately, in one smooth motion, in a straight line. Do not try to keep your grip.

The "football hold" is worth learning: the rabbit's head tucked into the crook of your elbow, its body supported along your forearm. Vets use it because it is secure and low-stress at once. For a quick look at the eyes, ears or teeth, vets use another hold: one hand behind the rabbit so it cannot back up, the other lightly covering its eyes and steadying the head so it does not bolt forward. It is the lowest-stress restraint there is.

NEVER

Lift a rabbit by the ears, ever. Never rely on the scruff alone to carry its weight: even where a grip at the neck is used to steady an animal, the body has to be supported underneath.

Skip trancing

You will see advice about flipping a rabbit onto its back to calm it, sometimes called trancing. Don't. Research measuring rabbits in that position found significant increases in respiration, heart rate and stress hormones. The stillness is a fear response the animal cannot escape, and it looks calm to the untrained eye, which is why the myth lasted. Repetition makes it worse: a rabbit turned over often goes still sooner because it has learned what is coming, and it tends to hide more and explore less afterward.

Building trust instead

- Most rabbits are calmest with all four feet on the ground, and many never learn to love being picked up even once they trust you. That is normal.
- Sit or lie down at the rabbit's level and wait. Let it come to you rather than reaching in. Hand-feed a green or a herb at floor level.
- Aim for a rabbit that is relaxed around you, not one that tolerates being carried. Pick-ups can stay rare.
- Train it to come when called and to walk into its carrier for a treat. A rabbit that rarely has to be scooped up makes vet trips far easier.
- Nail trims, grooming and health checks happen with four feet on a stable surface, never with the rabbit on its back. Long sleeves help, because hind nails can badly scratch an unprotected arm.

Body language & normal behavior

Rabbits tell you how they feel with posture, ears and sound, and most of it is easy to learn.

WHAT YOU SEE OR HEAR	MOOD	WHAT IT USUALLY MEANS
A binky: the midair leap and twist, all four feet off the ground	HAPPY	A rabbit that is overjoyed.
Flopping on its side, stretching the back legs out, legs tucked under the body	RELAXED	It feels safe.
Ears upright and relaxed; soft tooth grinding like a cat's purr	CONTENT	Calm and comfortable. Grooming itself or a bonded partner, and licking you, say the same.
A gentle nip	ASKING	An attempt to groom you or get your attention. A hard bite is fear.
Thumping a hind foot	ALERT	It senses danger, or is frightened, frustrated or unsettled.
Ears flat against the back; a crouch with tense muscles and the head pressed low	AFRAID	Worry and discomfort, or a wish for distance.
Standing on the hind legs to bat at anything close, sometimes with a growl; flicking the back feet	FRUSTRATED	It feels threatened, or wants space.
Loud, harsh tooth grinding, hunched with the belly pulled in	PAIN	Not purring. Abdominal pain, and a vet call (page 27).

Stress signals to stop on

Thumping a hind foot, a tense and rigid body, wide eyes, fast and shallow breathing, harsh tooth grinding, freezing in place, bolting or kicking. If you see these, set the rabbit down in one smooth motion, straight down and never dropped, and give it space.

A habit that points to a problem

Those are in-the-moment signals. A longer-running pattern is a different matter: circling the enclosure over and over, chewing the cage bars, over-grooming to the point of bald patches, constant hiding or freezing as the baseline, and any change in eating, drinking, activity or litter habits. These are signs of stress or illness. Rule out health first, then look at space, company and enrichment (pages 6, 20).

Normal, not naughty

- **Hiding** is how a prey animal rests, so every rabbit needs somewhere to retreat.
- **Digging** is a burrowing instinct. A rabbit without anywhere to dig gets stressed, and picks somewhere you would rather it didn't.
- **Chewing** comes from teeth that never stop growing, and it slows after neutering without ever stopping.
- **Marking territory** with chin secretions, urine and droppings is part of how a rabbit feels at home.
- **Being most active at dawn and dusk** is the crepuscular rhythm, and it is why exercise scheduled for the household's convenience misses.

Enrichment & common mistakes

The enrichment aisle is full of things to put in a hutch. The evidence points somewhere much less commercial.

What the research says

- **Companionship.** Solitary rabbits show less behavioral diversity and more awake inactivity than socially housed ones. A larger age difference between paired rabbits went with a lower friendship index, a measure of how close two rabbits are, which is a practical steer when choosing a companion.
- **Space, measured in a stress hormone.** Run access, hutch size and time of day all affect welfare-relevant behavior and fecal corticosterone in pair-housed pet rabbits. Space registers in a stress hormone, which is why permanent access beats a scheduled hour.
- **Structure.** In group-housed rabbits, an elevated platform let animals rest more comfortably and explore more. Somewhere to get on top of, and somewhere to get underneath, is worth building in from the start.

AWAKE INACTIVITY

A still rabbit reads as a contented rabbit from the sofa, and the measure exists because the two states look identical from across a room. A rabbit sitting motionless and awake for long stretches in a small space is showing the pattern the research associates with poorer welfare, not relaxing.

Priority order

1. A neutered, bonded companion, close in age
2. Permanent run access or a rabbit-proofed room
3. Unlimited hay, presented so it takes time to eat
4. A dig box
5. Platforms to get on and cover to get under
6. Chewing and shredding material: bamboo sticks, untreated willow, plain cardboard
7. Novel objects, last, and they are the cheap part

Common mistakes

MISTAKE	WHAT HAPPENS
Buying the cage sold as a rabbit cage	It is a fraction of the current standard. Confinement shows up as awake inactivity, which owners read as a calm rabbit.
Pellets as the main food	Low fiber is the biggest stasis risk, and pellets do not wear the teeth the way hay does.
One rabbit and toys instead of company	The research measured that gap, and toys were not what changed it.
Not spaying or neutering	In some strains, 80% of unspayed does develop uterine cancer by 3 years, plus marking, aggression and failed litter training.
Waiting overnight on a rabbit that stopped eating	That night can be the difference between a full recovery and a death.
A general small-animal vet	Rabbit physiology, anesthetic protocols and drug tolerances differ enough that a non-specialist can miss or mishandle the conditions in Section 07.
Trancing a rabbit to calm it	Measured heart rate and stress hormones say it is fear, not relaxation.

Companionship & bonding

The highest-value thing you can do for a rabbit, and the one that takes the longest to do properly.

A neutered, bonded pair does things a single rabbit does not: mutual grooming, resting in contact, and simply more behavior of every kind. A single rabbit with an attentive owner is a compromise, not an equivalent, and this is the finding the research most directly supports.

Choosing a companion

- Neuter both first. Hormones sabotage bonds that would otherwise work.
- Closer in age is better: the friendship index dropped as the age gap widened.
- A neutered male with a spayed female is the pairing usually recommended.
- Temperament matters more than size or breed.

How bonding goes, stage by stage

STAGE	WHAT YOU DO
1. Neuter, then wait	A male can stay fertile for up to six weeks after neutering, and hormones take weeks to settle, so wait about four weeks after surgery before the first meeting.
2. Vaccinate and quarantine	The newcomer gets its vaccination against rabbit hemorrhagic disease virus 2, RHDV2 (page 31), and two weeks in a separate space before it shares air or bedding with the resident.
3. Side by side	Two enclosures next to each other with a barrier, so the rabbits can see and smell each other and each can hide. Expect about a week of unrest.
4. Neutral ground	Short, supervised meetings in an area neither rabbit has lived in, lengthening day by day, ended before either is tired of it.
5. Moving in	Once they spend one to two hours together every day without trouble, they can share a living space.

IT IS WORKING WHEN

They lie together and groom each other.
Bonding takes weeks, and going too fast is how it fails.

SEPARATE AND GO BACK A STAGE IF

There is mounting of heads, biting, or chasing that does not stop. A bond is also failing when one or both rabbits lose weight or develop new behavior problems over the following weeks.

After the bond

A bonded pair travels together. A familiar rabbit alongside helps a rabbit stay calm in an unfamiliar place, so the partner comes to vet visits and on car trips even when only one is ill (page 39). A prey animal separated from its companion in a strange place carries two stresses instead of one.

Choosing a rabbit, quarantine & the first vet visit

Most of what decides the next ten years is settled before the rabbit comes home.

What a healthy rabbit looks like

LOOK AT	HEALTHY
Fur and skin	Clean and shiny, with no bald patches or wounds. Wet or matted fur under the chin or around the tail can signal illness.
Eyes, nose and ears	Eyes and nose clear. Ears clean, not crusty.
Behavior	Alert, curious, and willing to move without stiffness or limping.
The place	Clean. Ask what the rabbit has been eating and how it has been handled.

Visit in the early morning or the evening, when rabbits are most active, to judge personality. Larger rabbits are often calmer and sturdier, and smaller ones more delicate. Selling or giving away baby rabbits under 2 months old is illegal in many states, and a rabbit from a rescue is often cheaper in the end: adoption fees of \$25 to \$100 frequently include the surgery and an initial vet check.

The first vet visit

- Find a rabbit-savvy exotic vet before the rabbit arrives, and book the first exam for as soon as the rabbit is home (page 25).
- For a rescue rabbit, ask when it was last vaccinated, and bring what you know about its diet.
- The exam covers weight, body condition and the mouth. A full dental exam of the back teeth takes sedation, so a rabbit that is eating normally may not need one.
- Ask about a blood test for *Encephalitozoon cuniculi* (E. cuniculi), a parasite many pet rabbits carry (page 30), and about the vaccine schedule (page 31). Vets often test for the parasite at the first exam.
- Ask the vet to confirm the sex, and book the spay or neuter if it is not already done.

Quarantine

A newcomer that will share space with a rabbit already at home is vaccinated first and then waits two weeks in a separate space before they share air or bedding. Keep the diet exactly as the seller or rescue fed it for the first days, and change it over a week or two, because a sudden food change is a classic stasis trigger. Then the bonding stages on page 20 begin.

SETTLING IN

A new home is a stress. Give it hay, water and quiet, with the litter box already stocked with hay over it, and let it come to you rather than reaching in.

Sexing, spay & neuter

Not optional for a pet rabbit, and the cheapest route is often an adoption that includes it.

THE NUMBER THIS PAGE EXISTS FOR

In some strains, 80% of unspayed does develop uterine cancer by 3 years of age. That is the main reason vets spay a doe that will not be bred, and why spaying is treated as close to routine rather than as an elective extra. Spaying removes the uterus before the cancer can start.

Sexing

A vet can sex a rabbit by gently pressing the genital area to show a slit-like opening in a female or the penis in a male. A buck's (adult male's) testicles descend at 10 to 12 weeks, so a young rabbit can be hard to read. Ask the vet to confirm the sex at the first exam, before any pairing, because opposite-sex pairs breed unless both are altered.

What it changes

BENEFITS	
Females	Removes the uterine cancer risk. Hormonal marking stops, so litter training works. Chewing settles.
Males	No health benefit, but worth it for behavior: an intact buck is in constant libido, mounts other pets and objects, and may be aggressive toward other rabbits.
Pairs	Both rabbits are neutered, which makes bonding possible at all (page 20).

Timing and cost

WHEN	NOTES
Sexual maturity	About 3.5 to 4 months in small breeds, 4 to 4.5 in medium breeds, and 6 to 9 in giants. A buck can be neutered once the testicles have descended. A doe's simple ovariectomy (removal of the ovaries) is possible under a year old, and the usual time is at maturity, around 6 months, before fat builds up around the uterus.
Neuter	Typically \$200 to \$300.
Spay	More, since it is more invasive. Budget \$150 to \$500 or more overall, with exotic and metro clinics at the higher end.
Low-cost programs	Nonprofit clinics sometimes bring it down to around \$139 to \$150.
Adoption	Fees of \$25 to \$100 frequently include the surgery and an initial vet check, so adopting an already-altered rabbit is often the cheapest route overall (page 35).

Choosing who does it, and what to expect

Ask whether the clinic follows exotic-species fasting rules. A rabbit cannot vomit, and its stomach is never empty, so a fast longer than three hours is neither needed nor recommended, and a short one-to-two-hour fast to clear the mouth is the norm. A clinic that says withhold food overnight, the way it would for a dog, may not do many rabbits. Afterward, hay, vegetables and water go in front of the rabbit as soon as possible, and eating again is the number that matters: a rabbit that has not eaten within two to three hours needs its pain relief reviewed, not more waiting.

Molting, grooming & nails

Rabbits groom themselves thoroughly and cannot vomit, which is the whole reason this page exists.

Molting

Rabbits molt roughly every three months, and the timing and length of each shed vary, so one molt can pass almost unnoticed while the next fills the brush every day. A heavy molt is normal. The risk is the fur the rabbit swallows while grooming: a cat coughs up a hairball, and a rabbit cannot. Fur has to travel the whole digestive tract and come out in the droppings. That works unremarkably until the gut slows for another reason, such as low fiber, dehydration, stress or dental pain, and a heavy load of fur meets a gut that is not moving it. True blockages are uncommon and stasis usually has a separate trigger, but that is why a heavy molt is a stretch to watch closely rather than a shedding nuisance (page 27).

- **Brush at least weekly, daily during a molt.** Every hair on the brush is one the rabbit did not swallow. Angora and other long-coated rabbits need daily brushing all year.
- **Push hay and water hard through a molt.** Fiber and fluid keep swallowed fur moving.
- **Normal shedding is even** across the body. A bald patch that does not fill back in, redness or scabbing under missing fur, or clumps coming out outside a molt is a reason to ask a vet.

Nails

Trim every 6 to 8 weeks. Overgrown nails are uncomfortable to walk on and curl back into the pad. The quick is the blood vessel through the center of the nail, a pink line on a pale nail. On a dark nail, hold a flashlight behind it to see where the quick ends. Keep styptic powder out and open before you start, for the nick that eventually happens: pressing it on for a few seconds normally stops the bleeding, and it is not a reason to stop trimming.

A rabbit that fights every trim does better wrapped snugly in a towel with one foot worked free at a time, and with one or two nails done per sitting, so it does not associate the whole job with an ordeal.

Scent glands, baths and the rest

- **Scent glands.** A rabbit has a scent gland on either side of the anus that needs periodic cleaning. Have a rabbit-savvy vet or groomer do it, or show you the technique, because the area is sensitive and easy to irritate. Check it in the same session as the nails, every 6 to 8 weeks.
- **Never a full bath.** Rabbits groom themselves, and a soaked coat holds moisture and cold, and the struggle is stressful. Spot-clean a dirty patch with a damp cloth on that spot and dry it thoroughly.
- **A mucky rear end** needs the cause found, not just cleaning: diet, teeth, weight or arthritis (page 29).

MAKE GROOMING THE HEALTH CHECK

Every session is a chance to run your hands over the whole rabbit: lumps, scabs, sore hocks, a damp chin, a matted rear, a change in weight. Doing both at once means the check actually happens.

Is a rabbit legal where you live?

Legal without a permit almost everywhere in the United States, with two rules that are genuinely unclear.

This page covers all 50 states, the District of Columbia and New York City, which has its own rules: 52 jurisdictions. A pet rabbit is **legal with no permit in 50** and **unclear in 2**: no jurisdiction is recorded as barring it or as requiring a permit for a pet.

WHERE	STATUS	THE RULE
Minnesota	Unclear	Minnesota Rules 6216.0250 designates the European rabbit, <i>Oryctolagus cuniculus</i> , a prohibited invasive species with no strain or domestication qualifier, and Minnesota Statutes § 84D.05 bars possessing one except under a permit. None of the permit categories is pet-keeping, and the state's invasive species page restates the rule. What the rule says and what the state does about house rabbits are different questions: ask the state natural resources agency before you buy or move.
Nevada	Unclear	Nevada Administrative Code 503.110(1)(d)(5) names <i>Oryctolagus cuniculus</i> but labels the row "Wild European Rabbit", and unlike the chinchilla and rat rows it carries no domesticated-races wording. Pet rabbits are plainly sold in the state, but the text does not settle it. Clark County, Las Vegas and Henderson are stricter than the state, so check the municipality first.
Hawaii	Legal	Hawaii Administrative Rules § 4-71-2 names domesticated races of the European rabbit as a domestic animal, so the permit lists do not reach a pet rabbit. Bringing one to the islands still needs an import permit under Hawaii Revised Statutes chapter 150A.
District of Columbia	Legal	District of Columbia Code § 8-1808(j)(1)(C) permits it as a domesticated animal, and § 8-1808(i) separately bars selling a rabbit under 16 weeks old.
Michigan	Legal	Importing a rabbit calls for a certificate of veterinary inspection, as for any domestic rabbit.

Legal with no permit: 50 jurisdictions

Alabama, Alaska, Arizona, Arkansas, California, Colorado, Connecticut, Delaware, the District of Columbia, Florida, Georgia, Hawaii, Idaho, Illinois, Indiana, Iowa, Kansas, Kentucky, Louisiana, Maine, Maryland, Massachusetts, Michigan, Mississippi, Missouri, Montana, Nebraska, New Hampshire, New Jersey, New Mexico, New York State, New York City, North Carolina, North Dakota, Ohio, Oklahoma, Oregon, Pennsylvania, Rhode Island, South Carolina, South Dakota, Tennessee, Texas, Utah, Vermont, Virginia, Washington, West Virginia, Wisconsin and Wyoming.

Seven of them, Colorado, Illinois, Maryland, Michigan, Montana, Oregon and Washington, and also Nevada, let cities or counties be stricter than the state, so check your local ordinance (a city or county law) too.

THE RULES THAT ACTUALLY REACH RABBIT KEEPERS

For almost everyone, the restrictions that bite are local: city codes that cap animal numbers, zoning that treats rabbits as livestock rather than pets, and lease or homeowners' association terms that name rabbits. Check the city before the state, and the lease before either.

NOT LEGAL ADVICE

State legal status as of October 2026. This is a summary of state rules, read on 1 October 2026, and not legal advice. Rules change. Before you buy or move, check with your state wildlife agency and with your city or county.

Red flags & finding a vet

What to watch for, what to tell the vet, and how to find one before you need one.

BEFORE ANYTHING ELSE ON THIS LIST

Rabbits need a rabbit-savvy exotic vet, not a standard small-animal clinic. This is not snobbery about credentials: rabbit physiology, anesthetic protocols and drug tolerances differ enough that a vet unfamiliar with the species can miss or mishandle everything in this section. Find one before you need one, ideally through a local rabbit rescue.

Go to a vet today

WHAT YOU SEE	WHAT IT POINTS AT
No food and no droppings for 8 to 12 hours	GI stasis. Same-day, not overnight (page 27)
Droppings small, misshapen, or strung together with fur	Early stasis, hours before it becomes obvious (page 32)
Hunched posture with the belly pulled in, audible tooth grinding, or a bloated, tense abdomen	Abdominal pain, and gas in a gut that has stopped moving. Grinding here is pain, not contentment
Visible fly eggs or maggots in the fur	Flystrike. It can kill within 24 to 48 hours (page 29)
Drooling or a damp chin, dropping food while eating, weight loss	Dental disease (page 28)
Eye or nasal discharge, sneezing, crusted front paws	Snuffles, usually from the bacterium <i>Pasteurella multocida</i>
Head tilt	E. cuniculi or an inner ear infection (page 30)
Open-mouth breathing	An emergency at any hour
Diarrhea, appetite loss or lethargy during or after antibiotics	Possible enterotoxemia: call at once (page 31)
Sudden lethargy, hiding, or unwillingness to move	Rabbits hide illness. By the time it shows, it is usually well established

What to have ready when you call

When the rabbit last ate and what, when you last saw normal droppings and what they look like now, its current weight and the trend from the owner log, whether it is spayed or neutered, anything that changed recently (food, housing, a new pet), its vaccination status, and any medication given.

Finding a vet

Ask a clinic how many rabbits it sees, whether it follows exotic-species fasting rules for surgery, and who covers emergencies after hours. Not every emergency clinic sees rabbits, so find out in advance which one near you does, and write the numbers on the emergency card (page 34). Book a wellness exam twice a year: it catches dental changes and weight drift before they become emergencies, and the vet should look at the back teeth, which cannot be seen from the front.

GI stasis: what it is & why rabbits get it

Ask an experienced rabbit vet what kills more pet rabbits than almost anything else and this is the answer: the gut simply slowing down or stopping.

What it actually is

Rabbits are hindgut fermenters. The digestive system relies on continuous movement to process a high-fiber diet and to produce two kinds of droppings, including the nutrient-rich cecotropes the rabbit eats directly (page 32). When gut motility, the movement of food through the gut, slows or stops, gas builds up, painful bloating follows, and the balance of gut bacteria shifts dangerously. Untreated, that cascade can become life-threatening within 24 to 48 hours of onset.

Why rabbits specifically

Unlike many pets, a rabbit cannot comfortably skip a meal or two. Its gut needs near-constant input to keep moving, and going without food for even half a day can be enough to slow motility in a rabbit that is stressed or unwell. That is the opposite of how most mammals are built, and it is why a rabbit cannot tough out an off day the way a cat or dog can.

Triggers

TRIGGER	WHY IT MATTERS
Low-fiber diet	Insufficient hay slows motility over time. The single biggest risk factor, and the one entirely in your control.
Dental pain	Makes eating uncomfortable, and reduced intake alone can start the cascade.
Stress	A loud environment, a new pet or a vet visit can be enough to slow digestion.
Dehydration	Reduces gut lubrication and motility directly.
Pain from any other cause	A rabbit in pain from any source often stops eating, which starts the same cascade.
A heavy molt	Swallowed fur plus dehydrated gut contents can form a mass that is hard to pass (page 23).
Some medications	A few drugs used for other conditions slow gut motility as a side effect. Ask when anything new is prescribed.

STASIS EVEN ON A GOOD DIET

Hay is the single biggest prevention factor, but it does not make a rabbit immune. Stress, dehydration, dental pain or an unrelated illness can all trigger stasis in a rabbit with an excellent diet. Stasis is also not quite the same as bloat: bloat, severe gas buildup, is one dangerous consequence of stasis, but stasis can also show up as reduced motility with minimal gas.

GI stasis: signs, what to do & prevention

The signs arrive in an order, and the first one you can see without touching the rabbit.

Early warning signs, in the order they usually appear

1. **Reduced or absent fecal output.** The earliest and most reliable sign, and the reason a daily glance at the litter box is worth more than any other habit in this book.
2. **Smaller, oddly shaped, or fur-strung droppings** in the hours before output stops entirely.
3. **Reduced appetite**, picking at food without refusing it outright.
4. **Hunched posture** with the belly pulled in, the classic sign of abdominal pain.
5. **Teeth grinding (bruxism)** at a harsh, audible pitch, distinct from the soft tooth-purring of a relaxed rabbit.

WHY WAIT AND SEE IS DANGEROUS HERE

With most illnesses, a day of monitoring at home is reasonable. With GI stasis, that same day can be the difference between a rabbit that recovers fully and one that does not. A rabbit that has produced no droppings in 8 to 12 hours, or has stopped eating entirely, needs a same-day visit to a rabbit-savvy or exotic vet, not a "let's see how tomorrow goes."

What treatment looks like

Vet treatment typically means fluids under the skin, pain management and motility medication, along with identifying whatever triggered the episode, because stasis is very often the visible end of something else, most commonly dental pain. Syringe-feeding a critical care formula is often part of recovery, but it should be guided by a vet: force-feeding a rabbit with a real blockage rather than a slowdown can make things worse, and the two look similar from outside. About 70% of rabbits survive GI stasis, and most uncomplicated cases resolve with veterinary treatment over three to five days, but delayed cases can need days of hospitalization.

While you are getting to the vet

- Call first, and give the facts: when it last ate, when you last saw normal droppings, what changed.
- Go the same day.

Don't

- Don't syringe-feed without veterinary direction.
- Don't use pineapple juice, gas drops or any home remedy in place of the appointment. They are outdated, with no reliable evidence behind them, and they waste critical time.
- Don't wait for the morning to see if it passes.

Prevention, which is most of the answer

- Unlimited grass hay at 80% or more of the diet (page 13).
- Fresh water always available, and greens that carry moisture.
- Diet changes made gradually over a week or two, never overnight.
- A low-stress home, and a daily glance at the litter box to see that output looks normal in size and quantity.
- Brushing through heavy molts, so less fur is swallowed.
- Twice-yearly wellness exams, since dental pain is the most common hidden trigger.

Dental disease

One of the most frequent hidden causes of appetite loss, and one that can develop silently.

Cause	Rabbit teeth grow about 1 cm (0.4 in) a month, as much as 4 to 5 in (10 to 13 cm) a year, and an incisor that does not meet its partner can grow 1 mm a day. Long-strand fiber wears them down by grinding, so a diet short of hay lets them overgrow. Molar spurs form on the outside edges and cut the tongue or cheek, and incisors can stop meeting at all. Heredity adds to it: dwarf and lop-eared breeds are overrepresented, whatever the diet.
Signs	Drooling, or a permanently damp chin. Dropping food while trying to eat. Weight loss. Pawing at the mouth. Trouble grooming. Mouth sores or abscesses.
Response	A vet exam. The roots and back teeth cannot be seen from the front, so a vet confirms the problem with skull X-rays. Treatment is trimming the teeth under anesthesia with rotary tools, and in severe cases extraction.
Recovery	Dental exams and trims are repeated every 4 to 12 weeks for the rest of the rabbit's life, because the teeth keep growing. The prevention is unchanged: unlimited hay, from day one and for life.

WHY THIS PAGE MATTERS FOR THE REST

Dental pain is a trigger for GI stasis. A rabbit whose mouth hurts eats less, and a rabbit that eats less has a gut that slows. If your rabbit has had a stasis episode with no obvious cause, the teeth are the first place to look, which is why a full workup matters more than treating the stasis alone (page 27).

What you can check at home

- ☐ Lift the lips once a week. The top incisors should meet the bottom pair cleanly, with the top just in front.
- ☐ Watch the rabbit eat a piece of hay. It should take it and grind steadily, not pick it up and drop it.
- ☐ Look for a damp chin, drooling, or weight loss on the weekly weigh-in.
- ☐ Keep the twice-yearly wellness exams, and ask the vet to look at the back teeth.

NEVER TRIM A RABBIT'S TEETH YOURSELF

Nail clippers and wire cutters fracture the tooth, which leads to abscesses in the tooth or gum and enormous pain. This is a veterinary procedure under anesthesia with rotary tools. There is no home version of it.

Flystrike & snuffles

Flystrike (myiasis)

Cause	Flies lay eggs on soiled or damp fur, most often around the rear, and the eggs hatch into maggots within hours. The rabbits at risk cannot keep their rear end clean: a rabbit with diarrhea, tooth pain, arthritis or obesity, one living in a dirty enclosure, or one with an open wound. It is most common in warm weather but can happen all year.
Signs	Fly eggs or maggots in the fur, patches of wet fur and fur loss around the rear, lethargy, eating less, a bad smell, or collapse. The maggots can do extensive damage in a day and kill a rabbit within 24 to 48 hours.
Response	An emergency vet appointment right away, for even a single maggot, at any hour. Do not try to pick the maggots off or treat the rabbit at home, and do not dunk it in water to drown them: both cause pain and can send the rabbit into shock. The vet clips the fur, cleans the skin and removes the maggots, often under anesthesia, then gives pain relief and medication for the rest. In severe cases the damage is too great to save the rabbit.
Prevention	Look at the rear end, fur and skin every day, and twice a day in warm weather. Remove soiled litter and wet bedding every day. Keep the rabbit slim and moving so it can groom itself, have any wound checked, and ask the vet about a fly deterrent in summer. A rabbit with a permanently mucky bottom has a hidden cause, since dental pain and arthritis both stop a rabbit grooming.

Snuffles (upper respiratory infection)

Cause	Often <i>Pasteurella multocida</i> , a bacterium most adult rabbits carry without trouble, though other bacteria do the same job. Stress, poor ventilation, or ammonia from a dirty enclosure lets it take hold.
Signs	A thin discharge from the nose and eyes that thickens over time, sneezing, wheezing or noisy breathing, loss of appetite, lethargy, and the giveaway owners miss: crusty, matted fur on the insides of the front paws, from a rabbit wiping its own nose repeatedly.
Response	Call the vet promptly: it is contagious between rabbits. A vet should confirm it with a bacterial culture and a sensitivity test (a lab test that grows the bacteria to identify them and show which antibiotics work) rather than treating on the signs alone, because not every strain causes disease and only some antibiotics are safe for a rabbit (page 31).
Prevention	Fix the ventilation and the cleaning schedule alongside the medication. Pneumonia cases rise with the ammonia level in the enclosure.

OPEN-MOUTH BREATHING IS ALWAYS AN EMERGENCY

A rabbit breathing through its mouth is a same-hour call, whatever else is going on.

Sore hocks, bladder stones, uterine cancer & a parasite

Sore hocks (pododermatitis)

Pressure sores on the undersides of the hind feet, from wire or hard flooring or inadequate bedding, and made more likely by obesity. Rex rabbits and giant breeds are most prone. It starts as fur loss, red skin and swelling, then becomes ulcers and open sores, and untreated it reaches the bone. Treatment is anti-inflammatory medication, foot wraps and a flooring change. Prevention is solid, soft, dry flooring and a rabbit at a healthy weight, and catching the bald-patch stage is worth the weekly look.

Bladder sludge and stones

Caused by too much calcium in the diet, for instance from alfalfa fed to an adult, or from a lot of kale, spinach or dandelion greens. Signs are decreased appetite, lethargy, weight loss, teeth grinding and frequent urination, and stones are removed surgically. Grass hay for non-breeding adults is the prevention (page 13).

Uterine cancer

A significant risk in unspayed does. In some strains, 80% of unspayed does develop uterine adenocarcinoma, a cancer of the uterus, by 3 years of age, and it is the main reason vets spay a doe that will not be bred. Spay early, before it becomes a concern rather than after (page 22).

Encephalitozoon cuniculi (E. cuniculi)

A parasite carried by many pet rabbits, often with no signs. When it becomes active it can cause head tilt, and it contributes to recurrent GI stasis episodes. A head tilt can also come from an inner ear infection, and telling the two apart is the vet's job. Vets often test for it at the first exam, and when the test shows an active infection the treatment is a 28-day course of fenbendazole, a deworming drug, started before signs appear.

THE PATTERN ACROSS THESE CONDITIONS

Very little here is treated better than it is avoided. Sore hocks are prevented by soft, dry flooring and a healthy weight, bladder stones by a grass-hay diet and water that gets drunk, and uterine cancer by a spay. That is the argument for the twice-yearly exam.

CONDITION	CATCH IT BY
Sore hocks	Looking at the undersides of the hind feet every week for fur loss and red skin
Bladder stones	Noticing frequent urination, teeth grinding or weight loss, and asking about calcium in the diet
E. cuniculi	Asking about a test at the first exam, and treating a head tilt as a vet visit
Uterine cancer	Not waiting: a spay removes the risk, so it is a decision rather than a screening

Rabbit hemorrhagic disease vaccine & antibiotics

RHDV2 and the vaccine schedule

Rabbit hemorrhagic disease virus 2 (RHDV2) reached the United States in 2018 and has since spread through wild and pet rabbits nationwide. It kills fast: in a vaccine trial, 18 of 19 unvaccinated rabbits exposed to it died within 10 days. The virus travels on food, water and anything else it contaminates, so an indoor rabbit is not out of reach.

STEP	WHEN
First dose	From 4 weeks of age
Second dose	21 days after the first. Protection is full about two weeks after it.
Annual booster	Once a year. Vaccinated rabbits in a duration study held protective antibody levels for a full 12 months, and a booster at that point raised them sharply.
Side effects	Usually limited to a mild fever, some lethargy, or a small swelling where the needle went in.
Cost	The two-dose starter series runs about \$80 to \$180, and each annual booster about \$60 to \$75. The higher prices usually bundle a full exam, a nail trim or a microchip.

Pairing the yearly booster with one of the twice-yearly wellness exams keeps it from slipping.

Antibiotics and enterotoxemia

A routine antibiotic that is safe in a dog can be fatal in a rabbit. Certain antibiotics aimed at gram-positive bacteria, the large group that includes most of a rabbit's gut bacteria, wipe out the resident gut flora, and a toxin-producing bacterium, *Clostridium*, takes over: enterotoxemia, toxins flooding the bloodstream from a gut that has stopped working as a barrier. Rabbits move the fastest: lethargy, a rough coat, greenish-brown feces caked around the rear, and death within 48 hours. A rabbit can look healthy in the evening and be dead the next morning.

ANTIBIOTIC CLASS OR DRUG	DOCUMENTED RISK
Penicillins (penicillin, ampicillin, amoxicillin, amoxicillin-clavulanate)	Contraindicated in rabbits
Lincosamides (clindamycin, lincomycin)	Contraindicated in rabbits
Macrolides (erythromycin, tylosin)	Documented in guinea pigs and rodents; treat as risky in a rabbit and ask before use
Cephalosporins	Oral use is risky in rabbits

Oral dosing carries more risk than an injectable form of the same drug, because it passes straight through the gut where the bacteria live. Bring the drug list to the appointment, or simply ask: "Is this antibiotic one of the ones known to cause fatal diarrhea in rabbits, and have you prescribed it to a rabbit before?" A vet experienced with exotics will have an immediate answer.

IF IT STARTS DURING A COURSE

Any diarrhea, appetite loss or lethargy that starts during or shortly after an antibiotic is a call-the-vet-now situation, not something to monitor overnight. Do not wait for the next scheduled dose. Stopping the antibiotic is usually the first step the vet will want to take.

Reading droppings & cecotropes

The litter box is the best diagnostic instrument you own, and checking it takes five seconds a day.

Rabbits make two kinds

FECAL PELLETS

Small, brown, roughly round and somewhat dry, made mostly of undigested fiber. These are what you see in the litter box, in large quantities, all day.

CECOTROPES

A cluster of small, soft, shiny pellets like a dark brown mulberry or a bunch of grapes, coated in mucus. They pass at several points through the day and night, and the rabbit eats them straight from the source.

Cecotropes are not an accident and not a sign of anything wrong. They carry B vitamins and microbial protein that the gut bacteria made but that were not absorbed on the first pass, and eating them is a genuine part of rabbit digestion. A rabbit that cannot eat them eventually becomes malnourished, so do not stop the rabbit doing it.

What the litter box is telling you

WHAT YOU SEE	WHAT IT POINTS TO
Plenty of round, even, dry pellets	Normal output for a rabbit eating enough hay.
Fewer, smaller or oddly shaped pellets	The gut is slowing. Check what the rabbit has eaten today and act now rather than waiting for the count to reach zero.
Pellets strung together with fur or debris	Slowing motility, an early stasis sign. In a molt, brush daily and push hay and water (page 23).
No droppings at all for 8 to 12 hours	Same-day vet visit (page 27).
Soft, mushy pellets, or uneaten cecotropes stuck to the fur or floor	Too much rich food (pellets, treats or fruit) shifting the gut bacteria, or a rabbit that cannot reach them because of obesity, arthritis or another physical problem. Cut the rich food first, then look for a reason it cannot reach them.
Unformed, watery stool	True diarrhea. It is rare in adults and can point to parasites or inflammation, so a vet should see the rabbit. In a baby rabbit it is an emergency.

UNEATEN CECOTROPES ARE NOT DIARRHEA

They get mistaken for it, but true diarrhea is the unformed, watery kind, and an adult with a soft stool usually has a diet problem rather than an infection.

THE FIVE-SECOND HABIT

Know what your rabbit's normal output looks like, and look in the litter box every time you pass it. You are not counting, you are looking for a change in quantity or shape. It is the earliest signal this species gives you, and it is free.

Setup checklist & targets

Essential setup checklist

- ☐ Exercise pen, 4×4 ft (1.2×1.2 m) or bigger, plus run space (page 6)
- ☐ Solid, non-slip flooring and a waterproof tarp underneath (page 7)
- ☐ Large cat-litter-box-style box, with a hay rack over it
- ☐ Paper-based or compressed wood-pellet litter
- ☐ Grass hay, unlimited, with a rack or feeder (page 13)
- ☐ Plain timothy-based pellets and a measuring cup (page 14)
- ☐ Heavy, flat-bottomed water bowl, and a bottle if the chin gets sore (page 15)
- ☐ A hide or cardboard castle, and a platform to get on top of
- ☐ Dig box with soil, shredded paper or hay (page 19)
- ☐ Chew material: bamboo sticks, untreated willow, plain cardboard
- ☐ Nail clippers, styptic powder, and a brush (page 23)
- ☐ Hard-sided carrier with a hide spot (page 39)
- ☐ Cord tubing and the rest of the room proofing (page 10)
- ☐ Kitchen scale that reads in grams, and a room thermometer

Targets

TARGET	FIGURE
Enclosure space	8 sq ft (0.75 m ²) minimum
Exercise space	24 sq ft (2.2 m ²), 5 or more hours a day; permanent access is better
Room temperature	61 to 72°F (16 to 22°C) comfortable; at or below 80°F (26 to 27°C) always, and temperature plus humidity at 150 or less. In the cold: drafts and damp, not degrees
Hay	Unlimited, 80 to 85% of the diet
Vegetables	At least 2 cups per 6 lb (2.7 kg) a day, with 3 or more varieties of leafy greens
Pellets	1/8 to 1/4 cup per 5 to 6 lb (2.3 to 2.7 kg) daily
Treats	1 to 2 tbsp, once or twice a week
Water	About 120 mL per kg of body weight a day, changed daily
Nails and scent glands	Every 6 to 8 weeks
Vet exams	Twice a year, including the back teeth; the vaccine booster once a year

Before your rabbit comes home

- ☐ Room proofed, cords covered, and the pen set up before arrival
- ☐ Spay or neuter booked, or confirmed as already done (page 22)
- ☐ Rabbit-savvy vet found, and the first exam booked (page 21)
- ☐ A plan for a companion, and a quarantine space (page 20)

Emergency & quick targets

VET TODAY IF

No food or droppings for 8 to 12 hours (call at 8) · droppings small, misshapen or fur-strung · hunched posture or audible tooth grinding · bloated or tense abdomen · fly eggs or maggots in the fur · drooling or dropping food · eye or nasal discharge with crusted front paws · head tilt · open-mouth breathing · frequent urination or weight loss with teeth grinding · sudden lethargy or hiding · soft, unformed stool · diarrhea or appetite loss during or after antibiotics · panting, drooling or flat, unmoving collapse in the heat

READING	TARGET
Hay	Unlimited, 80 to 85% of the diet
Vegetables	At least 2 cups per 6 lb (2.7 kg) daily, 3 or more varieties of leafy greens
Pellets	1/8 to 1/4 cup per 5 to 6 lb (2.3 to 2.7 kg) daily
Room temperature	61 to 72°F (16 to 22°C); never above 80°F (26 to 27°C)
Exercise	24 sq ft (2.2 m ²), 5 or more hours a day
The line	8 to 12 hours with no food or droppings is same-day, not overnight

Your numbers

Rabbit-savvy vet _____

Normal weight (g) _____

Out-of-hours clinic that takes rabbits _____

Spayed or neutered on _____

Rabbit's name and date of birth _____

Last vaccination _____

HAVE THIS READY WHEN YOU CALL

When it last ate, when you last saw normal droppings, current weight and the trend, whether it is neutered, what changed recently, and any medication given. Bring a bonded partner along: a familiar rabbit helps it stay calm.

THE ONE HABIT THAT CATCHES MOST OF THIS

A five-second look in the litter box every morning. Not counting, just noticing whether there are fewer droppings than yesterday. It is the earliest signal this species gives you, and it is free.

Budget & shopping list

United States retail ranges. The low end is basic but correct gear, the high end is premium.

INITIAL SETUP	TYPICAL COST
Foldable metal exercise pen	\$40 to \$100
Large cat-litter-box-style litter box	about \$37
Food and water dishes	\$6 to \$18
Nail clippers	about \$10
Carrier	about \$32
Equipment, the five items above	\$125 to \$197
Spay or neuter, if not already done	\$150 to \$500 or more
Vaccine starter series (two doses)	\$80 to \$180

A hay feeder, cord tubing, flooring, a hide, a dig box, chew material and a kitchen scale are extra and unpriced here. The rabbit is extra too: \$25 to \$100 as an adoption fee, which often includes the surgery, and low-cost programs sometimes bring a spay or neuter to around \$139 to \$150.

MONTHLY ONGOING	TYPICAL COST
Hay, the bulk of the diet	\$20 to \$40
Pellets	\$12 to \$20
Fresh vegetables	\$15 to \$50
Litter	\$15 to \$25
Food and litter, monthly	\$62 to \$135

ADDING IT UP	TYPICAL COST
Two wellness exams a year, at \$60 to \$100 each	\$120 to \$200
One vaccine booster a year	\$60 to \$75
Every year after the first , food, litter, exams and booster	\$924 to \$1,895
The first year , equipment, surgery, starter series, food, litter and two exams, without the adoption fee	\$1,219 to \$2,697

KEEP THIS SEPARATE FROM THE BUDGET ABOVE

An emergency fund of \$500 to \$1,000. A single GI stasis workup can exceed \$1,500, and rabbits need an exotic vet whose rates run above a general clinic's. It decides whether an emergency is survivable or a decision, and it is worth having before the rabbit arrives.

First 30 days

Before day 1

- ☐ Pen up, room proofed, cords covered, and the litter box already stocked with hay over it (page 10)
- ☐ A supply of whatever the rabbit is currently eating, so nothing changes on day one (page 12)
- ☐ Rabbit-savvy exotic vet found, and the number written on the emergency card (page 34)

Day 1

- ☐ Hay, water and quiet. No handling, no visitors, no other pets in the room
- ☐ Weigh in grams and photograph the rabbit as a baseline (page 16)
- ☐ Fill in the numbers on the emergency card

Week 1

- ☐ Look in the litter box every morning: you are learning what normal output looks like for this rabbit (page 32)
- ☐ Sit on the floor nearby each day without reaching for the rabbit (page 17)
- ☐ Book the first wellness exam, and confirm the spay or neuter status and vaccination history (page 21)
- ☐ Keep the diet exactly as it was. Change nothing yet

Weeks 2 to 3

- ☐ Begin moving hay, pellets or greens to your chosen kinds, mixing old with new over a week or two
- ☐ Start the owner log with a weekly weigh-in (page 42)
- ☐ Add greens one variety at a time, watching the droppings before adding the next (page 14)
- ☐ Extend run time toward permanent access as the rabbit's confidence grows

Week 4

- ☐ Review the log for weight trend and output. Steady weight and plentiful, even droppings is the goal
- ☐ A first hands-on check: incisors, jawline, hocks, rear end, and a nail trim if due (page 23)
- ☐ Add enrichment, one change at a time (page 44)

Days 31 to 90

- ☐ Book the spay or neuter if it is not done (page 22)
- ☐ Start thinking seriously about a companion (page 20)
- ☐ Fill in the pet-sitter sheet before you need it (page 41)
- ☐ Confirm the out-of-hours clinic still takes rabbits, and how far it really is

Symptom quick reference

SYMPTOM	LIKELY CAUSE	ACTION
No food or droppings for 8 to 12 hours	GI stasis	Rabbit vet today (page 27)
Fewer or smaller droppings than yesterday	Early stasis or dehydration	Check what it has eaten, push hay and water, call if it continues (page 32)
Hunched, belly tucked, harsh tooth grinding	Abdominal pain	Vet today. Grinding here is pain, not contentment (page 18)
Drooling, dropping food, damp chin	Dental disease	Vet. The back teeth need sedation to see (page 28)
Fly eggs or maggots in the fur	Flystrike	Emergency vet now. Do not soak the rabbit or pick them off (page 29)
Nasal or eye discharge, crusted front paws	Snuffles	Vet, and ask for a culture before antibiotics (page 29)
Head tilt	E. cuniculi or inner ear infection	Vet promptly (page 30)
Open-mouth breathing	Airway or respiratory trouble, or heat	Emergency, same hour (page 29)
Frequent urination, teeth grinding, weight loss	Bladder sludge or stones	Vet today. Review calcium in the diet after (page 30)
Bald or red patches on the undersides of the hind feet	Sore hocks	Soften the flooring now, vet if the skin is open (page 7)
Soft cecotropes stuck to the fur or floor	Too much rich food, or can't reach them	Cut pellets and treats first, then check weight and mobility (page 32)
Unformed, watery stool	Diarrhea, rare in adults	Vet today; an emergency in a baby rabbit (page 32)
Diarrhea or appetite loss during antibiotics	Enterotoxemia	Call the vet now, before the next dose (page 31)
Panting, drooling, hot ears, lying flat	Heat stress	Cool room, damp cloth on ears and feet, call the vet (page 8)
Thumping, freezing, hiding constantly	Stress, or too little space and no companion	Look at space and company before the rabbit (page 18)
Weight loss between weekly weigh-ins	Several causes, dental first	Vet, and bring the owner log (page 16)
Mounting, spraying, sudden aggression	Intact hormones	Spay or neuter. Not a training problem (page 22)
Heavy shedding in tufts	A molt	Brush daily, push hay and water, watch the droppings (page 23)

Daily, weekly & seasonal routine

Daily

- ☐ Look in the litter box. Quantity and shape, five seconds (page 32)
- ☐ Top up hay so it is never empty, and refresh the water
- ☐ Measured pellets and the day's greens, at least three varieties (page 14)
- ☐ Clean the toilet area and any accidents (page 11)
- ☐ Run time, ideally permanent, and at dawn and dusk if it is not
- ☐ Look at the rear end, fur and skin, twice a day in warm weather (page 29)
- ☐ Thirty seconds of watching: posture, breathing, eyes, appetite, how it moves

Weekly

- ☐ Weigh in grams and log it (page 42)
- ☐ Clean the whole enclosure
- ☐ Hands-on check: incisors, jawline, hind feet, rear end, lumps (page 28)
- ☐ Brush at least weekly, and daily instead during a molt

Every 6 to 8 weeks

- ☐ Nail trim, with styptic powder to hand
- ☐ Scent gland check, in the same session

Monthly

- ☐ Feel the body for condition, not just weight (page 16)
- ☐ Review the log for slow trends rather than single readings
- ☐ Rotate or add one piece of enrichment (page 44)

Seasonal

- ☐ Molts come roughly every three months: brush daily and push hay and water hard (page 23)
- ☐ Summer: watch the room against the 80°F (26 to 27°C) line, and check the rear end twice a day (page 8)
- ☐ Winter: watch for drafts and damp bedding, not the thermometer alone

Twice a year

- ☐ Wellness exam, and ask the vet to look at the back teeth (page 25)

Once a year

- ☐ The vaccine booster, paired with one of the wellness exams (page 31)

Power outages & heat waves

A rabbit needs no equipment running to survive, which makes a blackout mostly a temperature problem, and heat is the one to worry about.

When the power goes out

Do

- **Keep feeding.** This is the one place the reptile rule runs backward: a rabbit that stops eating for a day is in more danger than one that is a few degrees cool. Hay and water stay in front of it the whole time, and water goes in more than one container.
- **In a summer outage,** freeze bottles of water for the rabbit to lie against, use cool wet towels, shade the enclosure, and move it to the coolest room, usually a tiled bathroom or a basement. Cucumber, melon and apple help with water. Read the thermometer instead of guessing.
- **In a winter outage,** keep the pen draft-free, away from windows and doors, and raised off the floor. Add plenty of dry bedding hay or straw, extra hay for insulation, and check that the water has not frozen, including the ball in a bottle nozzle.
- **Move the rabbit out rather than wait,** once the room is past the safe band and you cannot bring it back. Decide at hour two, not hour eight.

Don't

- Don't treat a cool rabbit as a reason to stop feeding.
- Don't plunge an overheated rabbit into cold or ice water.
- Don't assume it has recovered once it looks calmer. A vet visit is still needed after heat stress.

OUTAGE KIT

Frozen water bottles, towels, a battery fan, a thermometer, extra hay and bedding, a carrier, and your vet numbers written on paper.

In a heat wave

The line is about 80°F (26 to 27°C), and temperature plus humidity should stay at 150 or less. Check the room through the afternoon, since a house without air conditioning keeps climbing. Keep the rabbit out of direct sun, move to the coolest room, and use airflow and a frozen water bottle wrapped in a towel. A rabbit living outdoors comes inside for a heat wave.

Leaving town, transport & moving

A rabbit travels badly and notices every change, so the planning matters more than the equipment.

Leaving town

Appetite, drinking, droppings and weight are checked every day, and the rear end twice a day in warm weather, and that job passes to a sitter while you are gone. Having someone look after the rabbit in its own home is usually best, because it keeps things familiar. Walk the sitter through the pet-sitter sheet in person (page 41), tell your vet that someone else may bring the rabbit in, and make sure the sitter knows what normal droppings look like. A rabbit that must stay elsewhere takes some used, unsoiled nesting material from home.

Transport and vet trips

- A sturdy, hard-sided, well-ventilated carrier the rabbit cannot chew through, with room to lie down and turn around. A wire cage flexes under braking and lets the rabbit watch every passing car, which for a prey animal is a stream of predators.
- Drape a towel over most of the carrier, and give it somewhere to hide: a cardboard box or small tunnel tucked inside. Add a toy or a handful of clean bedding from home so it smells familiar.
- Line the carrier with hay, and offer water. A rabbit that nibbles on the way has a gut that keeps moving, and a long stretch with nothing to chew is a stasis risk.
- Secure the carrier in the car, in the cabin, out of direct sun, never in a closed trunk, and never left in a parked car, even briefly.
- Take a bonded partner along even when only one is ill, and keep the trip short where you have a choice of vet.
- Moving house is a stress, a known stasis trigger. Keep the diet identical, set the pen up first, and watch the droppings closely.

FILL IN AND LEAVE BY THE PEN

Pet-sitter sheet

Everything a sitter needs on one page. Walk them through it once in person before the first solo visit.

Rabbit's name _____

Rabbit-savvy vet _____

Normal weight, and where the food is _____

Out-of-hours clinic _____

My phone _____

Backup contact _____

Every visit, every day

- ☐ Look in the litter box first. There should be a lot of round droppings. Write down roughly how many compared with yesterday. This is the most important thing on this sheet.
- ☐ Top up hay so the rack and the box are full. There is no such thing as too much hay.
- ☐ Fresh water. Wash the bowl rather than topping it up.
- ☐ Measured pellets: _____ per day, and the greens in the fridge. No other food, no treats.
- ☐ Clean the toilet area and any accidents.
- ☐ In warm weather, look at the rear end, fur and skin twice a day, and tell me about any wet, dirty patch.
- ☐ Sit with the rabbit for a few minutes and watch it. It should be moving around, curious and eating.

Please don't

- Feed anything not on this sheet. Bread, crackers, cereal, yogurt drops and iceberg lettuce are all wrong here, whatever the packet says.
- Pick the rabbit up unless we have agreed on it. If you must, support the chest and the back end at the same time and stay low to the ground.
- Flip the rabbit onto its back. It looks calm, and it is not.
- Let the rabbit into any room I have not shown you. Cables are the danger.

CALL ME STRAIGHT AWAY IF

There are noticeably fewer droppings than yesterday, or none at all · the rabbit has not touched its food · it is sitting hunched with its belly tucked in, or grinding its teeth loudly · its belly looks bloated or feels tense · there is discharge from the eyes or nose · it is drooling or dropping food · it is breathing with its mouth open · its head is tilted to one side · there is anything crawling in its fur, or any wet, dirty patch around its back end · it is panting or lying flat in the heat. If I don't answer, call the vet number above.

Owner log

One row a week, filled in on weigh-in day. Photocopy this page, or track digitally. Consistency matters more than the format.

DATE	WEIGHT (G)	DROPPINGS	HAY EATEN	APPETITE	GROOMING, BEHAVIOR, ANYTHING NOTICED

WHY BOTHER LOGGING

A change in weight is often the first sign of illness, and nobody notices a slow decline by eye. Sixteen rows is four months, which is long enough to see a real trend rather than a bad week.

Care, vet & bonding log

Care task log

TASK	LAST DONE	DUE	DONE
Nail trim, every 6 to 8 weeks			
Scent gland check, every 6 to 8 weeks			
Whole enclosure clean, about weekly			
Hay restock			
Vaccine booster, once a year			

Twelve-month planner

Tick the box in the month you did it. Month 1 is whichever month you start in.

TASK, BY MONTH	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10	11	12
Weigh and review the log	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Nail trim	☐		☐		☐		☐		☐		☐	
Wellness exam	☐					☐						
Vaccine booster	☐											

Bonding log

DATE	SESSION LENGTH	HOW IT WENT: CHASING, MOUNTING, GROOMING, RESTING IN CONTACT

Vet visit log

DATE	WEIGHT (G)	REASON AND FINDINGS, INCLUDING THE DENTAL CHECK	FOLLOW-UP

Enrichment checklist & log

Setup

- ☐ A neutered, bonded companion, close in age (page 20)
- ☐ Permanent run access, or a rabbit-proofed room
- ☐ Hay in tubes, bundles and racks, so eating it takes time
- ☐ A dig box with soil, shredded paper or hay
- ☐ A platform to get on top of, and cover to get underneath

Monthly review

- ☐ Move or add one item, without taking away a hiding place
- ☐ Scatter greens through hay or a snuffle mat instead of putting them in a bowl
- ☐ Restock chew material: bamboo, untreated willow, plain cardboard
- ☐ Check the rabbit is using more of the space than last month, not less

Enrichment log

DATE	WHAT CHANGED	HOW IT WENT, AND WHETHER TO REPEAT

WHAT NOT TO DO

Don't buy toys instead of solving space or company: the research measured that gap and toys were not what closed it. Don't take away a hiding place to add a new object. Don't change three things at once, or you will never know which one the rabbit responded to. And don't read a still, quiet rabbit in a small pen as a contented one, because awake inactivity is exactly what the companionship study measured.

REFERENCE

Glossary, A to G

APOP	The Association for Pet Obesity Prevention, a nonprofit whose rabbit body condition chart is the 9-point scale on page 16.
Awake inactivity	Sitting still while awake for long stretches. A welfare measure rather than a mood, and associated in the research with solitary or confined housing. Page 19.
Binky	The midair leap and twist, all four feet off the ground, of a very happy rabbit. Page 18.
Bonded pair	Two rabbits that have been properly introduced and now live together, groom each other and rest in contact. Page 20.
Bruxism	Tooth grinding. Soft and quiet means a contented rabbit, like a cat's purr. Harsh and audible means pain, and the two are easy to tell apart once you have heard both. Pages 18, 27.
Cecotropes	Soft, dark, shiny, clustered droppings, like a bunch of grapes, produced through the day and night and eaten directly from the source. A genuine part of digestion, not a problem. Page 32.
Cecum	The fermentation chamber after the small intestine, where gut bacteria break down fiber. It is why a rabbit is called a hindgut fermenter. Page 12.
Celsius (°C)	The metric temperature scale, shown beside Fahrenheit throughout. A comfortable room is 16 to 22°C. Page 8.
Centimeter (cm)	A metric length, one hundredth of a meter and about 0.4 in. Teeth grow about 1 cm a month. Page 28.
Corticosterone	A stress hormone. A study measured it in rabbit droppings to show how run access and space change stress. Page 19.
Crepuscular	Most active at dawn and dusk. It is why permanent run access beats an hour scheduled for the household's convenience. Page 6.
Culture and sensitivity test	A lab test that grows bacteria from a swab to identify the germ and show which antibiotics work against it. Page 29.
Dewlap	The fold of skin under the chin, larger in does. A permanently damp dewlap points at drooling, and so at dental disease. Pages 16, 28.
Doe and buck	An adult female and an adult male rabbit. Pages 13, 22.
E. cuniculi	Short for <i>Encephalitozoon cuniculi</i> , a parasite many pet rabbits carry silently. When active it can cause head tilt. A vet can test for it and treat it. Page 30.
Enterotoxemia	Toxins flooding the bloodstream after certain antibiotics wipe out the gut bacteria and a toxin-producing <i>Clostridium</i> takes over. It can kill within 48 hours. Page 31.
Fahrenheit (°F)	The temperature scale used first in this package. A comfortable room is 61 to 72°F, and about 80°F is the heat line. Page 8.
Fecal pellets	The round, dry, brown droppings you see in the litter box, made mostly of undigested fiber. Page 32.
Fenbendazole	A deworming drug. A 28-day course is the treatment for an active <i>E. cuniculi</i> infection. Page 30.
Flystrike	Also called myiasis: fly eggs laid in soiled fur hatching into maggots that eat into the skin. Can kill within 24 to 48 hours. Page 29.
Foot (ft)	A length of 12 inches, about 30 cm. Used for pen and enclosure sizes. Page 6.
Friendship index	A measure of how close two rabbits are, used in the companionship study. It fell as the age gap between pairs widened. Page 20.
GI (gastrointestinal)	Relating to the stomach and intestines, the digestive tract. Page 26.
GI stasis	The gut slowing or stopping. The most common life-threatening emergency in pet rabbits, and the reason for the 8-to-12-hour rule. Pages 26, 27.
Gram (g)	A metric weight, one thousandth of a kilogram, the unit a kitchen scale shows. The weekly weight log is kept in grams. Page 16.
Gram-positive bacteria	A large group of bacteria that includes most of a rabbit's gut bacteria. Antibiotics aimed at them can wipe out the gut flora. Page 31.

REFERENCE

Glossary, H to Z

Hemolytic anemia	A shortage of red blood cells because they are destroyed faster than they are made. Onion, garlic and chives can cause it. Page 15.
Hindgut fermenter	An animal that digests fiber in the cecum, after the small intestine. It is why the gut must keep moving and why fiber is not optional. Pages 12, 13.
Inch (in)	A length of 2.54 cm. Used for sizes and for how fast teeth grow. Page 6.
IUCN	The International Union for Conservation of Nature, which keeps the global list of threatened species. The wild European rabbit is listed as Endangered. Page 4.
Kilogram (kg)	A metric weight of about 2.2 lb. Water intake is figured per kilogram of body weight. Page 15.
Kit	A baby rabbit. Page 12.
Lumbar spine	The lower back. An unsupported, struggling rabbit can fracture it with its own hind legs. Page 17.
Meter (m) and square meter (m²)	A metric length of about 3.3 ft, and the metric measure of floor area, 1 m ² being about 10.8 sq ft. Page 6.
Milliliter (mL)	A metric volume, one thousandth of a liter, about a fifth of a teaspoon. A rabbit drinks about 120 mL per kilogram a day. Page 15.
Millimeter (mm)	A metric length, one tenth of a centimeter. An incisor with nothing to wear against can grow 1 mm a day. Page 13.
Molar spur	A sharp point on an overgrown back tooth that cuts the tongue or cheek. Not visible from the front, which is why a vet needs X-rays and sedation to see it. Page 28.
Motility	The movement of food through the gut. When it slows, gas builds up and the bacteria shift: GI stasis. Page 26.
Ovariectomy	Surgical removal of the ovaries, the spay operation, possible as a simple procedure in a rabbit under a year old. Page 22.
<i>Pasteurella multocida</i>	A bacterium most adult rabbits carry without trouble, and the usual cause of snuffles when stress or poor ventilation lets it take hold. Page 29.
PDSA	The People's Dispensary for Sick Animals, a United Kingdom veterinary charity, cited on the Sources page for flystrike.
Pododermatitis	Sore hocks: pressure sores on the underside of the hind feet, caused by wire or hard flooring, or obesity. Page 30.
Pound (lb)	A weight of about 0.45 kg. Body weights and food portions are given per pound. Page 14.
RHDV2	Rabbit hemorrhagic disease virus type 2. Highly contagious, frequently fatal, and carried on food, water and anything else it contaminates, so indoor rabbits are not automatically safe. A vaccine protects against it. Page 31.
RSPCA	The Royal Society for the Prevention of Cruelty to Animals, a United Kingdom animal welfare charity, cited on the Sources page for housing, behavior, health and travel.
Snuffles	Upper respiratory infection, most often <i>Pasteurella multocida</i> . Look for crusted front paws as much as for a runny nose. Page 29.
Square foot (sq ft)	A measure of floor area, 1 sq ft being about 0.09 m ² . The space standard is given in it. Page 6.
Styptic powder	A powder that stops bleeding from a nail trimmed too short. Keep it open before you start. Page 23.
Tablespoon (tbsp)	A cooking measure of about 15 mL. A week's treats are 1 to 2 tbsp. Page 15.
Trancing	Flipping a rabbit onto its back until it goes still. Measured heart rate and stress hormones show this is fear, not relaxation. Don't. Page 17.
Uterine adenocarcinoma	A cancer of the uterus. In some strains, 80% of unspayed does develop it by 3 years of age, which is why spaying is near-routine. Pages 30, 22.
VCA	VCA Animal Hospitals, a United States veterinary hospital network that began as Veterinary Centers of America, cited on the Sources page.
X-pen	A foldable metal exercise pen. The current standard for rabbit housing, in place of a cage or hutch. Page 6.

REFERENCE

Sources

Where the numbers in this package come from, so you can check them yourself.

Veterinary manuals and clinical references

- Merck Veterinary Manual: management of rabbits; housing of rabbits; nutrition of rabbits; bacterial and mycotic diseases of rabbits; and the pet owner page on selecting a rabbit. The 61 to 72°F range and the 150 temperature-plus-humidity limit, water intake, maturity by breed size, sexing, the uterine cancer rationale for spaying, the culture before snuffles treatment, the *E. cuniculi* test at the first exam, the 3-hour fasting limit and the 2 to 3 hour eating bar after surgery, and the healthy-rabbit checks.
- VCA Animal Hospitals (VCA, originally Veterinary Centers of America): health problems in rabbits; dental disease in rabbits; gastrointestinal stasis in rabbits. The 80°F ceiling, bladder stones, sore hocks, tooth growth, the 4 to 12 week dental schedule, and why clippers must never be used on teeth.
- PetMD: gastrointestinal stasis in rabbits, for the eight-hour figure, the roughly 70% survival rate and the three to five day recovery; and the Flemish giant rabbit page for giant breed size.
- Lafeber Company: tips for grooming your rabbit, for the 6 to 8 week nail and scent gland interval. North Carolina State University College of Veterinary Medicine: caring for your pet rabbit, for bowl versus bottle and the sore chin.
- Royal Society for the Prevention of Cruelty to Animals (RSPCA): rabbit environment, health, behavior, bonding, transport and holiday care pages. Cleaning, twice-daily rear-end checks, breed risks, body language and leaving a rabbit with a sitter. People's Dispensary for Sick Animals (PDSA): fly strike in rabbits, for what to do and not do.
- Association for Pet Obesity Prevention (APOP): rabbit body condition score chart. Avian and Exotic Animal Clinic: the RHDV2 vaccine, for the starting age, interval and side effects.

Research

- Companionship counts: investigating social housing conditions and welfare in privately owned rabbits, Applied Animal Behaviour Science. A study of run access, hutch size and time of day and their effects on behavior and stress hormone levels in pair-housed pet rabbits, Applied Animal Behaviour Science.
- A study of single versus paired housing and rabbit body temperature and behavior in a shelter in the United Kingdom, Animal Welfare. A study of environmental enrichments and the behavior of growing rabbits housed in collective pens.
- Bosco-Lauth and colleagues (2024), Viruses: vaccination against rabbit hemorrhagic disease virus 2 using a baculovirus recombinant vaccine provides durable immunity in rabbits. The 12-month booster and the trial deaths.
- Irving-Pease and Larson (2018), Trends in Ecology and Evolution: the correction of the story that rabbits were domesticated by decree.

Husbandry references

- House Rabbit Society: the housing, diet, hay, GI stasis, rabbit droppings, lifespan and indoor and outdoor hazards pages. Space standards, the 80 to 85% hay share, the twelve-hour emergency line, outdoor risks and cord proofing. Wisconsin Humane Society: litter box training your rabbit.

The law

- Minnesota Rules 6216.0250 and Minnesota Statutes § 84D.05; Nevada Administrative Code 503.110; Hawaii Administrative Rules § 4-71-2 and Hawaii Revised Statutes chapter 150A; District of Columbia Code § 8-1808; New York City Health Code § 161.01; and each other state's rules, read on 1 October 2026.
- Prices were last checked in October 2026.

REFERENCE

Where the sources disagree

Where credible sources give different numbers, this package prints one and says why.

TOPIC	WHAT THE SOURCES SAY	WHAT THIS PACKAGE USES
The not-eating alarm	8 hours (a veterinary information site); 12 hours (a rabbit welfare group); fasting beyond about 24 hours risks fatty liver disease	Call at 8 hours, emergency at 12. Same-day vet contact the moment a rabbit skips a meal
Pellet portions	Roughly 1/8 to 1/4 cup of pellets per 5 to 6 lb, and sources vary on the exact ratio	1/8 to 1/4 cup per 5 to 6 lb, held at the low end for giants
Vegetable portions	Roughly 1 to 4 cups of chopped vegetables per several pounds, depending on the source	At least 2 cups per 6 lb a day, with 3 or more varieties of leafy greens
Hay share	80 to 85% of the diet; about 85%; 80% or more	80 to 85%, unlimited
Lifespan	Indoors 8 to 12 years, and some reach 14 or even 16; outdoors 3 to 5 years; wild 1 to 2 years	8 to 12 indoors, some to 14 or 16; 3 to 5 outdoors
When to spay or neuter	Males from when the testicles descend, 10 to 12 weeks; does at maturity, around 6 months; maturity 3.5 to 4 months in small breeds to 6 to 9 months in giants	By breed size: bucks once the testicles descend, does usually around 6 months
Fasting before surgery	Overnight, as for a dog; no more than 3 hours, because a rabbit cannot vomit and its stomach is never empty	No more than 3 hours (1 to 2 is typical), and eating again within 2 to 3 hours after
Time to run	An hour a day; 5 hours a day; permanent access	At least 5 hours a day, and permanent access is better
Water: bowl or bottle	Rabbits drink more from an open bowl; some rabbits get a sore chin from one	A heavy bowl by default, and a bottle if the chin gets sore
Heat line	Optimal 61 to 72°F; risk climbs past about 80°F (26 to 27°C); temperature plus humidity of 150	All three, each for its own job

Version history & about

What changed in each edition, so a printed copy can be placed.

Version history

This is edition 3.0 (Oct 2026). The store page shows the current edition; re-download free if yours is older. Where this list and a page disagree, the page wins.

- **3.0, Oct 2026.** Rebuilt on the current outline, 49 pages. Safety: first vaccine dose from 4 weeks of age, a second 21 days later, then a yearly booster; a doe's uterine cancer risk now 80% by 3 years in some strains, so spaying follows breed maturity (bucks once the testicles descend at 10 to 12 weeks, does usually around 6 months); room comfortable at 61 to 72°F (16 to 22°C), heat line about 80°F (26 to 27°C), and temperature plus humidity at 150 or less, with the earlier 77°F cooling step dropped; vegetables at least 2 cups per 6 lb (2.7 kg) a day with 3 or more varieties of leafy greens; flystrike means an emergency vet for even one maggot, with no picking them off and no soaking; scent glands cleaned by a vet or groomer, or learned from one; brushing at least weekly, daily in a molt; bladder stone signs now frequent urination, teeth grinding and weight loss. Legal: a new page on the law in all 52 jurisdictions, legal in 50 and unclear in Minnesota and Nevada. Costs: equipment \$125 to \$197, food and litter \$62 to \$135 a month, a year after the first \$924 to \$1,895, the first year \$1,219 to \$2,697. Other changes are wording only.
- **2.1, Sep 2026.** Safety: comfortable range 61 to 72°F and a heat ceiling of 80°F; nails and scent glands every 6 to 8 weeks; fasting before surgery no longer than 3 hours, with eating again within 2 to 3 hours; the stasis line read as 8 to 12 hours everywhere. Other changes are wording only.
- **2.0, Sep 2026.** Rebuilt, 39 pages. Replaced by 3.0.
- **1.0, Sep 2026.** First edition, 22 pages. Replaced by 2.0.

This package is a husbandry reference compiled from the listed sources and cross-checked against current veterinary guidance at the time of publication. It is not a substitute for a rabbit-savvy exotic veterinarian, and nothing in it should delay a vet visit. Treatments described here are for recognizing what a vet may do, never for use at home. The law page is a summary as of October 2026, not legal advice.

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